Doomsday &
The Days After

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Earthbound

COL-311701

Again and again, she has been haunted by the same dream.

In it, her eyes are clouded by mist, and when she tries to speak, her words come out garbled.

She is wrapped in a vast void, boundless and bare.

Terror seizes her. She opens her mouth and lets out her first cry.

Baby Girl in a Blanket: *cry*

But her faint cry is swallowed by the howling of a storm, its cruel wind tearing all things asunder.

Somewhere deep within, she senses the vastness of the world she's entered, yet not a single corner of it feels meant for her.

Baby Girl in a Blanket: *cry*

She begins to slip into unconsciousness.

But vaguely, through the cold, she hears the bark of a dog and feels a warm, wet snout against her numb face.

Sled Dog: Woof ... Woof woof!

Kozlov: Easy now, easy! Settle down, you cheeky girl! What've you found this time? Don't tell me it's another little bear.

Kozlov: Oh dear!

His smile vanishes into a look of open shock.

Urgent footsteps press into the soft snow, reaching her ears and then—

The world spins around her.

Kozlov: You poor child, look at you, chilled to the bone!

Kozlov: Those tiny little hands, like ice.

He holds her close to him, tucking her under his coat. The world shrinks in an instant.

Baby Girl in a Blanket: *cry*

But this cramped place holds such warmth.

The howling storm can no longer reach her. Her frozen limbs begin to thaw, and a deep sense of safety settles in.

Kozlov: You are safe now, little one.

Kozlov: There is nothing to fear.

Kiperina: One, two, three ...

Kiperina: No more, no less—just seven.

Kiperina: Just how it was before I left.

New Office, Plesetsk

The girl gives a satisfied nod as she turns her gaze away from the tropical fish in the tank.

After days of observation on her return from space, the end of her long quarantine feels like stepping out from another world. At last it seems like she has her feet planted on solid ground again.

But a drifting voice halts the smile rising on her lips.

Hissabeth: In fact, I ordered ten, but with the "Storm," logistics have been a complete mess.

Hissabeth: The leader said unless one of us is dying from a severe ornamental fish fillet deficiency, we'll have to wait our turn on the exotic fish list.

Hissabeth: He bred these new ones himself, and because he thinks our lovely little teleport disks will save him a ton of trouble someday, he's loaned them to us from his personal collection.

Kiperina: Are you saying that ...

Hissabeth: Oui, we have seven, just not the same pals as before.

The Melusine lifts one of her hidden siblings from the coils of her hair.

Hissabeth: So, listen up, you lot: no sneaky snacking this time, or we're paying for it. And we don't have that kind of money.

Snake I: Mais enfin! That's your fault for insisting on recreating the exact same lab at this branch! Let it go already!

Snake I: This is all that mouthy, overcharging salamander's fault. We haven't even got this month's allowance yet, and you're already splashing cash around like it grows on trees!

Hissabeth: We are still working on the data Kiperina brought from the space. Maintaining a consistent research environment will help keep our thinking on track, non?

Han Zhang: Hold on, hold on, did I just hear one of your snakes accuse me of overcharging? My prices are completely fair! Hell—I gave you them for practically a steal!

Han Zhang: Don't underestimate the pricing on getting identical tables and chairs in times like these. It's not exactly easy to get your hands on them.

The tiny salamander has stirred from its nap and launches into a spat with the serpentine siblings.

But their loud commotion seems almost impossibly distant to Kiperina.

Kiperina: The "Storm" and reversion.

Just saying the words seems to strike her with an unexpected harshness. As though she hadn't been ready for it.

She tries to avert her eyes, but she is drawn back to the eco-tank again.

The fish dart playfully through the water. She used to feel so much joy watching them, but then ...

Kiperina: They're not the same ones as before.

Kiperina: They're gone.

A wave of dizziness sweeps over her.

She feels like she has returned to the weightless void of space, but now without the company of the stars.

In the endless darkness, a colossal presence stirs. Its pull catches her, and she begins to fall.

Hissabeth: So, what's your plan?

Kiperina: Hmm?

Her fading awareness is drawn back to earth by an envelope waving before her eyes.

Kiperina: This is ...

Hissabeth: Knew it. You were off floating in the stratosphere again, weren't you?

Hissabeth: Voilà! This is a letter from the St. Pavlov Foundation—addressed to the "Esteemed Astronaut," no less.

Hissabeth: Seems the Foundation's quite interested in what we pulled off, so they're teaming up with Laplace to throw a banquet-meets-scholarly-exchange sort of do to celebrate.

Hissabeth: Everyone's on the list—names you know and more than a few you won't.

Hissabeth: What's with that look?

Kiperina: I ... I just did what I could. It really isn't something worth celebrating.

Kiperina: Maybe there might be something else I should be doing. Like—

She pauses for a moment, then lets the words leave her lips.

Kiperina: About the "Storm" ... Are there any updates on the "Storm," and could there be something I can do to help?

She longs for good news, though she could not possibly explain what kind of news she is hoping for exactly.

But all she is met with is the composed expression on Hissabeth's face.

Hissabeth: The data you brought back has definitely been helpful. We've already made great progress.

Hissabeth: But you're with Laplace now. You have to understand, when it comes to a problem like the "Storm," it won't be solved quickly.

The researcher gives her little astronaut friend a gentle pat on the shoulder.

Hissabeth: Be patient. You've done your part; now it's time for us office-bound eggheads to take over.

Hissabeth: Bien sûr, we don't usually say things like this, but come on, you just came back from space. You nearly died up there.

Hissabeth: What you need right now is a bit of rest and relaxation, not work.

The little astronaut's brow remains furrowed.

Hissabeth: You know what—here, take this.

Three familiar items, along with the invitation, are pressed into Kiperina's arms.

Kiperina: These are the teleport disks we used before, yes?

Hissabeth: They're new and improved, based on the data from your trip. In theory, you only need to think of the destination to trigger these things.

Hissabeth: The banquet's in a week. If you can't sit still till then, it might be the perfect chance to help us test them out and collect a bit of field data, non?

A subtle light returns to the girl's sky-blue eyes.

Kiperina: No problem, Miss Hissabeth! You can leave it to me!

But a thought hits her, and she falters again.

Kiperina: But, to use them, I need a destination to teleport to.

Kiperina: Where should I go?

Hissabeth smiles, perfectly at ease.

Hissabeth: It's all up to you.

Laplace Branch Hallway

Kiperina: ...

Kiperina closes the office door behind her and lets out a soft sigh.

Name Day: Miss Kiperina, is something the matter?

Name Day: I'm surprised to see our brave astronaut looking so glum.

A Long Winter

COL-311702

A rather surprising duo approaches from the far end of the hallway.

Name Day: I assumed Hissabeth summoned you to tell you about the banquet, yes?

Voyager: Hm?

Kiperina: Nothing. I'll do whatever I must do.

Kiperina: You'll be going to the banquet too, won't you?

Name Day: Yeah, we'll all be there.

Name Day discreetly eyes the teleport disks clutched to her chest, then, reading the mood, steers the conversation elsewhere.

Name Day: But before the banquet, your little friend and I need to make a trip to one of the Foundation's branches.

The mention of her friend immediately captures Kiperina's attention.

Kiperina: Are you saying that you and Voyager ... Um, may I ask what for?

Name Day: So the thing is you saw how Voyager experienced all those unusual arcane fluctuations.

Name Day: Given the Foundation's interest and the fact that Voyager hasn't been formally registered yet, they'd like her to visit ahead of time.

Name Day: That way, we can complete the formalities before the banquet.
And if time permits, I believe the scholars at headquarters are hoping to learn a little more about her.

Voyager: A journey.

Voyager: The road ... is ... so beautiful.

Following Voyager's meaningful glance toward Name Day, Kiperina understands what her friend is trying to say.

Kiperina: You mean the road has beautiful sights along the way, so you're happy to go?

Voyager: *nod*

Kiperina: I remember you mentioned that even the nearest Foundation branch is still very far from here, right, Mr. Name Day?

Kiperina: I don't really know where Voyager is from, but sometimes she seems a little unfamiliar with such basic things. I'm not sure ...

Name Day: Don't worry. She can take care of herself. And besides ...

He turns his head, glancing over at the delicate and seemingly harmless girl beside him.

Name Day: Voyager can wield that arcane skill of hers quite proficiently. I think she'd be able to get out of any trouble we might find ourselves in.

Kiperina: But ...

His words don't do much to ease her mind, until her friend smiles up at her.

Voyager: I want to go.

Voyager: Want to see ... this planet ...

Kiperina: You mean you want to travel the whole world?

Kiperina: So you've already decided what you want to do next.

Voyager: *nod*

The excitement in her friend's eyes lifts Kiperina's spirits, though it comes with a strange, unspoken melancholy.

Brushing off the odd sensation welling up inside, she lets herself smile in return.

Kiperina: Alright. If you've made up your mind, I won't stand in your way.

Kiperina: However, be careful on the road ahead. Don't go around talking to strangers, and certainly don't accept any food from them.

She holds out her fingers, counting off every precaution she can think of.

Name Day: You know you could come too, if you'd like.

Name Day: That way Voyager will have someone to keep her company. After the paperwork's finished, we'll head to the banquet together.

The invitation is tempting, but after a brief pause, Kiperina shakes her head.

Kiperina: Thank you, but, no, I've already promised Ms. Hissabeth I'd help with her research.

Kiperina: I think I have my own destination.

It's simply that she hasn't found it yet.

Name Day: Excuse me, Ms. Hissabeth. I just need to double-check something with you.

Name Day: Just a while ago, I happened to pass Kiperina in the hall just now. She seems a little out of sorts.

Name Day: We agreed she'd stay at the branch and rest up properly for a few days.

Name Day: But she told me she intends to continue assisting with your research. Sorry, what's going on?

Name Day's typical courtesies seem to have fallen by the wayside as he bites straight into the point.

Despite that, Hissabeth is as cool as ever.

Hissabeth: Hah! You think we didn't want to give her a break? She beat us to it before we could even open our mouths.

Hissabeth: I just brought up the banquet, and she practically had an allergic reaction to the idea, like, "No, no, I don't need a party. I just need to work."

Hissabeth: Fate has a sick laugh at your expense, and what do you do? Act like nothing happened, brush off the pain, rushing headfirst into the next big noble cause.

Hissabeth: I just don't get it. It seems like everyone here can't help but be a martyr. Yes, myself included.

The Melusine shakes her head and tosses the file she was reading onto the desk rougher than she should.

Hissabeth: It made her an excellent little astronaut, I admit it, but honestly, I don't understand where it comes from.

For a brief moment, the young man is at a loss for words.

Name Day: Staying busy sometimes is the best way to help you stop thinking.

Name Day: She might believe she chose her path and braced herself for the consequences. But knowing something is coming isn't much help for when you actually experience it.

Name Day: I'm not sure that's a good idea to send her out into the world so soon after her first "Storm."

Though he favors a more measured pace, it's clear the person across from him sees things differently.

Hissabeth: If she takes things slow, I think she'll be even more likely to go mad. She's the kind to charge in before she knows which way is up.

Hissabeth: It's a good thing. It means she's tough, and I'd bet she's better than any of us at finding the right balance.

Hissabeth: Before she sets sail, she needs to decide on her destination for herself.

Doomsday

COL-311703

Kiperina reaches the end of the hallway, wearing a heavy frown, then turns back, her steps tracing the same path again and again.

Kiperina: Hmm.

Han Zhang: Come on, now, don't tell me you still haven't made up your mind?

The salamander pops its head out with restless impatience.

Han Zhang: So Miss Snakehead just wants you to test those new teleport disks, am I right? Come on, kid, sounds to me like you've got a free pass to go anywhere.

Kiperina: But where is "anywhere"? The world is just so big.

Kiperina: I'm sorry. I think my indecision has wasted your time.

Her remorseful face makes Han Zhang squirm a little. It rubs at its skin, not sure of what to say.

Han Zhang: Ah, you've got nothing to apologize for. I'm the one who decided to tag along.

Han Zhang: These teleport disks are going to be hot stuff soon, but Laplace isn't likely to be offering them up to the public just yet.

Han Zhang: Which means, if I want to keep digging into how these things actually work, and I don't want to keep begging that mean snakehead, then I'll just have to ride your coattails for the next little while.

Han Zhang: Listen, wherever you go, I go. If you take a couple extra minutes, so what? It's not the end of the world. Take your time. Think all you like.

Something in his phrasing catches Kiperina slightly off guard.

Kiperina: "The end of the world" ...

Kiperina: I used to believe in all those prophecies about the end of the world. I remember once when I was five when we performed in a town where there was this old fortune-teller lady.

Kiperina: She said that one day all that we love will be gone. The earth will split open, then the waters will rise.

Kiperina: I remember being so frightened when I heard that. I rushed into the tent and hugged Mr. Kozlov tight. I didn't even say anything. He was worried about me for a long time after that.

A thought dawns in her mind and spreads across her face.

Kiperina: I still remember it was in Murmansk.

Kiperina: It was where Mr. Kozlov found me.

Kiperina: He told me about it when we returned there for a performance. That was ten years ago.

Kiperina: The year was 1977.

Han Zhang: Oh? Sounds like you might want to pay that place a visit?

Kiperina: I ...

She hesitates, then nods, her face resolute and certain.

Kiperina: Yes.

She pulls out the first teleport disk.

Kiperina: She whispers the destination in her mind, invoking the "Teleport" ritual.

She takes a deep breath.

Kiperina: My destination is Murmansk.

Scattered memories of the city flood her mind. The ships in the port, the towering statues ... Memories flowing away in reverse to a distant past.

A warm coat shields her from the snowstorm, and a tent provides the canopy for a small world filled with laughter and joy.

The ritual takes hold. The disk shakes in her grasp, and without warning, another word surfaces in her thoughts:

Home.

[English text unavailable]

COL-311704

Kozlov: Heads up, your dear Aunt Natalya is making her grand entrance!

In the distance, a slender figure slips into the tent.

Audience: Oh my gosh! It's like she can really fly!

The crowd holds their breath. Even the gasps grow hushed and hesitant.

She walks a wire barely a finger thick. A single slip would send her plummeting from dozens of meters above.

Yet she moves as if walking on solid ground. From afar, it looks as though she's walking on thin air.

Finally, she reaches the far end and greets the audience with a poised salute. After a moment of stunned quietude, thunderous applause bursts forth.

Audience: Amazing, Utrennyaya! Truly amazing!

With a sea of applause, the man smiles down at the little girl beside him.

Kozlov: There, you see? Nothing to worry about.

Kozlov: Aunt Natalya's not going to fall, Andreas's knives won't miss, and Bajon's not suddenly going to chomp on your sister Lena.

Kozlov: We pitched our big top good and strong, and no storm's taking it down. Even if the ground shakes or water comes rushing in, we'll still be safe inside.

Kozlov: That's why you must smile, Alia.

Kozlov: Forget what that fortuneteller said, child. The world's not ending, not anytime soon.

Suburb, Murmansk

The cold wind howls, and the deep snow makes every step a struggle.

But none of it slows her down.

Kiperina: I'm almost ... Not much farther. It's just ahead.

Kiperina: I remember it so clearly. The circus was right over there, by that little lake.

???: Hello! Hello!

She hears a faint voice call out to her, but there's nothing behind her except the white snow.

Han Zhang: Down here!

Following the voice, she glances down. A small head emerges from the opening of her coat.

Kiperina: What is it, Mr. Lizard?

Kiperina: I'm sorry. I got distracted while using the disk. I think we ended up a little off course.

Kiperina: But I promise we're almost there.

The little salamander leaps up in a burst of outrage.

Han Zhang: Lizard? What lizard? I'm a salamander!

Kiperina: Oh? Really?

Kiperina: I'm sorry. I guess I never knew the difference.

Its little head shakes.

Han Zhang: Ah, no, that's not even what I wanted to say!

Han Zhang: What I wanted to ask is, where are we really headed? I mean, you get what I'm saying, don't you?

Shards of frozen snow whip against her skin, and the wind's roar quietens Han Zhang's voice to a whisper.

Kiperina: Hmm? Mr. Liza—uh, I mean, Mr. Salamander, what did you just say?

Kiperina: I can't hear you!

Han Zhang: What I'm saying is—no more—don't—everything's—

The storm rages. The whipping snow covering the words of the tiny salamander.

Kiperina: Please, get back in my coat for now. It's too windy out here!

The icy gusts hit her face like sharp blades. Her skin starts to flush with an odd, feverish warmth.

Kiperina: Huff ... huff ... This was careless.

Kiperina: It's so cold here. I should've brought a thicker coat.

She pauses, uncertain. Maybe it would be better to head back after all.

But with her goal so close, Kiperina pushes her stiffening legs forward. All sense of caution being taken with the wind.

It seems almost second-nature to her.

Kiperina: I'm almost there.

Kiperina: Huff ... huff ...

She has been moving blind against the onslaught of snow, wandering much longer than she planned. The stiffness and cold in her legs begin to radiate across her body.

Kiperina: There it is!

She finally sees what she's been looking for, and her snow-covered boots, heavy with cold, begin to move with miraculous speed.

Kiperina: This is it! Over this small slope! That's where the circus was!

Kiperina: Hmm?

She climbs up to the peak of the slope, and finds herself solid.

Nothing's there.

Kiperina: That's odd. Why?

She looks around as if in a daze but her view tilts and spins with every turn of her head.

Then the muffled impact of a heavy object falling into the snow.

Kiperina: Hmm?

After a moment, her brain sluggishly registers. The "heavy object" was her.

Han Zhang: I said, that's enough! You're freezing to death, kid. Keep going like this and you're done for!

Han Zhang: Where are the other teleport disks? Hand them over. I'm taking you back.

Something scrambles onto her chest, shouting words she can barely make out.

Kiperina: Go back?

Kiperina: Back to where?

Kiperina remembers the words that drifted to her through the storm. Words she tried to shut out.

Han Zhang: Just stop, kid! Where are you even going?

Han Zhang: Don't you remember? Everyone from your circus was swept away by the "Storm"!

Kiperina: Oh, I forgot.

Kiperina: What am I saying? I couldn't ever forget. Ms. Hissabeth told me everything.

Kiperina: They are ... gone.

And then her consciousness begins to slip away.

But this time there won't be anyone to shield her with a coat, to craft a tiny haven from the storm.

All that she loved has vanished. For her, the end of the world has already come.

Kiperina: ...?

But as sight and touch fade, she catches a faint sound.

It sounds like footsteps.

But how could that be?

Yet the sound grows nearer with each passing moment.

At last, a voice rings out through the howling wind, different from the one she had hoped for, yet it is unmistakably real.

Woman: Heavens! Come on, child, pick yourself up, please.

As her last shred of consciousness fades, two arms—warm and strong, just like she remembered—wrap around her.

A Warm Place in the North

COL-311705

Kiperina: Hmm?

The soothing sound of a faint metallic clink reaches her dreams, and Kiperina stirs up from her slumber.

Cabin in the Snow

Kiperina: This is ...?

The room is slightly old-fashioned but warm.

The wind still howls, shaking the windows from the outside, but within this little sheltered world, it soon fades away.

Kiperina props herself up in bed, the thick blanket sliding down her chest.

Kiperina: No wonder I feel so warm.

Her companion, along with its weighty dwelling, leaps onto her belly.

Han Zhang: You're finally awake! You scared the life out of me!

Han Zhang: If I let anything happen to you, everyone back home would've turned me into salamander jerky!

Han Zhang: Hey now, don't try getting up yet! She said you need to warm up your hands and feet a little longer.

Kiperina: "She"?

Han Zhang gestures outward as a woman in her thirties steps out from what looks like the kitchen.

Woman: That's right, dear. Just rest for a while.

Woman: The frostbite's already been taken care of, but the ointment will work better if we keep it and you warm.

Woman: Come now, let me tuck you in.

Kiperina: Oh. Okay.

Her tone is warm and easy. Kiperina pauses for a moment, then lies back down without protest.

Kiperina: Were you the one who saved me?

Kiperina: I don't know how to thank you enough. If it weren't for you, I ...

A tray laden with steaming soup, bread, and roasted sausages is placed at Kiperina's bedside.

Woman: Anyone would have done the same. Falling down in the snow like that, the cold could have killed you.

Woman: You go ahead and eat something now.

Kiperina: Thank you.

Han Zhang: Larissa sure knows her way around the kitchen. Not to worry. I already tested the food for you.

Kiperina sits up, placing the tray on her lap.

She thinks she isn't hungry at first until the aroma of the food fills her nose.

Kiperina: I suppose I could eat.

The sausages and bread soon fill her empty stomach, mixing with the hot soup that brings a comforting warmth that spreads out as if seeping through her bones.

The gloom in her heart fades, and she feels a sudden surge of renewed energy.

Woman: How are you feeling? A little better?

Kiperina: Yes ... I ...

Kiperina: I'm doing much better.

The woman furrows her brow.

Woman: My dear, your face is still telling me otherwise.

Kiperina falls silent for a moment.

Shame and regret begin to surface, rising like the steam from her bowl.

Kiperina: I-I just never thought it could be so simple.

Kiperina: That a simple bowl of soup and a blanket would make me feel like this.

Kiperina: Losing something important, never seeing the people you love again. But does this mean people can just go on living as if nothing has changed?

Her hands shake, yet her eyes are unbearably dry.

If only she could just shed a tear, perhaps it would bring her a little relief.

But there's nothing there.

Kiperina: Is everyone like this?

Kiperina: Or is it only me?

Han Zhang: You ...

Han Zhang opens its mouth, as if on the verge of speaking, but the words don't come out. The only sound in the room is the wind slipping through the crack in the door.

After a moment, warm hands gently rest on Kiperina's shoulders.

Woman: That's not it, child.

Woman: I don't know what you've been through, but I can tell that you're strong.

Woman: And there's nothing wrong with being strong. Your family would never hold that against you. So—

Her hands gently cradle Kiperina's face.

Woman: Lift your head, dear.

She meets blue eyes as clear as a bright sky.

Then a strange realization strikes her. As if she's seen those eyes before.

Before she can clarify her thoughts, she finds herself speaking.

Kiperina: You ...

All at once her world is swallowed by darkness.

Literally.

Kiperina: Oh.

Han Zhang: Huh? Why'd the lights go out? Oof! What did I just bump into?

Woman: Oh no! That must be the generator acting up again.

Woman: The machine's been around since they retired it from the drilling site years ago. We just fixed it up last month. I guess that fix didn't take.

Woman: Let's light a candle for now. I think there's one more around here, just a moment.

The sound of rummaging through boxes moves sporadically around until, after a moment, a faint candle flickers, casting out a dim light.

Woman: At least we can see each other.

Woman: But I'm not sure that we can hold out until the snow stops. Hmm, this may be tricky.

Kiperina: The generator ...

Kiperina thinks for a moment before lifting the blanket from herself.

Kiperina: Maybe I can fix it. Can I take a look?

Days of Yore

COL-311706

Han Zhang: Yes! That's the ticket!

After a few flickers, the lights inside the room come back on.

Woman: Impressive. Where did you learn how to tinker with machines like that?

Kiperina falters for a moment under the woman's admiring eyes.

Kiperina: Have you heard of those old stories about the end of the world? I used to believe in them, so I studied a lot about things like homemade generators and survival skills.

Kiperina: I thought that, with enough preparation, I could protect everything around me from disaster. But ...

Kiperina: In the end, it didn't make a difference.

She realizes this isn't a topic she is eager to discuss right now. She looks around the room.

It's strange, though; for a "home," it lacks a certain lived-in quality, and as a "holiday cabin," it feels too much.

Kiperina: Speaking of which, what is this place?

Woman: This cabin used to belong to a bear hunter. I made some changes, brought in some furnishings.

Woman: For now, it's just a hut open to all weary travelers. I would never turn anyone away.

Noticing Kiperina's questioning look, the woman smiles.

Woman: You think it's a little odd, don't you? Why would I be out here in such a remote place? I have my reasons.

Woman: We're about ten kilometers west of Zapolyarny; to the northwest, there's a drilling site. I work as the doctor there, and my husband is a mechanic.

Kiperina: That's quite far on foot.

Woman: Yes, it took us quite a while to get out here, but I didn't expect the weather to turn against us like this.

The woman stares out the window as the snow continues to pile outside.

Woman: The storm doesn't seem like it'll let up anytime soon. Let's just pass the time, then.

Woman: It all began a long time ago.

Woman: Back then, my husband and I were still young. We had good jobs in the city.

Woman: Then, one day, he came rushing home with a pile of papers.

Years Ago, Moscow

Arseny: Look at this! These fools are insane!

Arseny: They want to dig a deep well, digging through the earth all the way to the deepest depths.

Arseny: It's not for oil or any other minerals, but just to find out what's at the earth's core!

Arseny: Tell me, is there really anything more ridiculous than that?

The man points to a line on the paper, his face glowing with a beaming smile.

Arseny: They're recruiting, and they need mechanics and a doctor.

Arseny: So, what do you say, Larissa?

Woman: We stayed for several years. Our first child was even born in their dormitory.

Woman: Heh, doesn't it all seem ridiculous to you?

Kiperina: No, it's not like that.

Kiperina: Whether it's the Earth's core or the edge of the universe, discovery is always valuable.

Kiperina: No one person can complete such a massive task. But if everyone does what they can, it's not impossible.

Woman: Arseny—my husband—he often says the same thing.

From the woman's fading smile, Kiperina senses something is amiss.

Kiperina: Are you saying that the project was not going well?

Woman: There were many difficulties that we hadn't anticipated, but in the end, we worked together to overcome them.

Woman: The deeper the well went, the more we believed that one day we would uncover the mysteries down below.

Woman: Until they claimed we had opened the gates of hell.

Years Ago, Borehole Field

Driller I: I heard it, and there's no question, that sound could only come from hell itself!

Driller II: You think that's bad? I've seen it with my own eyes!

Driller II: I was smoking outside a few nights ago when I saw this—freakishly tall—figure near the kennels.

Driller II: I didn't really know what I was looking at. How could a person possibly be two or three meters tall, eh?

Driller II: And that was the night those dogs died. That thing was only about ten meters away from me at the time!

Driller I: We've got to stop this thing! Who knows what we could let out!

The crowd's fear spreads like wildfire.

But in the end, a bright, cheerful laugh drowns out the flame.

Arseny: Enough, enough, comrades! You don't really believe all that silly talk, do you?

Arseny: That sound was just the wind. As for the bear, Yakov and the others are already chasing it down.

Arseny: I see, everyone's been worn out lately, but pull yourselves together, comrades! Didn't we train for this?

Arseny: We're standing on the crust; beneath that is the mantle, and the Mohorovicic discontinuity is in between. Where do you think hell is supposed to be?

Sometimes, all it takes is a single voice for the flames of anxiety to subside.

Woman: Arseny has always been that way. He hasn't changed since we first met.

Woman: At times, he's almost like a kid still, always causing trouble, but when he takes the lead, people can't help but follow him.

Pride shines in the woman's eyes, but her smile changes.

Woman: He shouldn't have stood up like that.

Woman: That evening, I was called to attend to a worker with a sudden fever, leaving Arseny to watch over our eldest daughter in the dormitory.

Woman: The next morning, they found him lying in the snow.

Woman: Blood ran from the house all the way outside, and our child was gone.

Woman: They called it a punishment from hell itself.

Between the Wind and Snow

COL-311707

Kiperina is left speechless for a moment. She never imagined the story would take a turn like this.

Kiperina: I'm so sorry. That's such a horrible thing to have happened to you.

Woman: The one who should apologize is me, child. Such a tale, no one would feel happy hearing it, да?

Woman: I hadn't planned to say all this, but somehow, it's such an odd thing. I hope I haven't upset you.

The story clutches at her heart, and a question is lodged in her throat, one that another listener asks on her behalf.

Han Zhang: Wait, seriously, you mean a monster from hell attacked your husband?

Woman: No. How could that be?

Woman: The well's only a meter wide; how could anything dangerous have come from it?

The woman offers a strange smile that slowly turns cold.

Woman: Besides, I'm a doctor. His wounds were caused by a knife.

Woman: And I found the bloodstained knife a few meters away.

Woman: So, I brought the hounds in and had them follow the scent to track down that "monster."

Hound: Woof-woof! Woof! Woof!

The hounds bark wildly as a fearful face peeks out from the shadows of the building.

A face she recognizes.

Woman: Mr. Vasily.

Woman: What are you doing here?

Driller II: Is that blood on his clothes?

Driller III: He's the one! Grab him!

Woman: Vasily was a pitiable man. I've known him for a long time.

Woman: He came to my mother's clinic late one night, carrying a strange old man in his arms. Back then, he was the most kind-hearted young man in town, and everyone loved him.

Woman: I used to help at her clinic. Every time he walked by, he'd take out chocolate from his pocket and say it was a treat for "good kiddies."

She closes her eyes and pauses for a moment.

Woman: When I saw him again at the drilling site, I could hardly believe I was looking at the same man.

Woman: He would have been in his early forties then, but he was hunched and gaunt. If someone told you he was sixty, you would have believed it.

She sighs, eyes filled with sympathy, but there is something darker in it.

Was it anger or hatred? Maybe both? Perhaps neither?

Kiperina cannot say for sure. In the end, she simply asks in a whisper.

Kiperina: What happened to make him like that?

Woman: He never spoke of his past. I only learned of it from the others.

Woman: He said something he shouldn't have when he was drunk, and the following day, he was taken away. Nobody heard from him for a long time.

Woman: They say he was sent to the Vorkuta mine. Arseny once shared a dorm with him. He said that he often woke up in the night, screaming.

Woman: He said that Vasily always claimed he didn't say anything wrong, and that he knew who informed on him, but every time he would tell us a different name.

Woman: Whoever it was, that place broke him, and he no longer believed in anyone or anything. The kind gentleman I knew as a child might as well already be dead.

Kiperina: Is that why he did something so terrible?

Kiperina: How is she? I mean, your daughter.

Woman: Our child ... my most precious treasure ...

Woman: She vanished.

Vasily: Curious, very curious! She should be right here.

Vasily: Ugh!

The butt of a rifle hits his back, and the man tumbles into the snow.

Driller II: Talk now!

Driller III: This old man's been out of his mind all day. He probably doesn't even remember. The whole thing is a mess.

Driller III: The snow keeps coming down. A child that small, in this weather ...

The man on the ground leaps up as if scorched by the snow.

Vasily: I don't remember! Please! Just listen to me! We can't keep drilling!

Vasily: The sounds from below ... I know those sounds! Something horrible is going to happen, something very bad!

Vasily: They're going to take us all there, to hell! I won't go back there!

He screams, his voice eventually faltering and fading.

Vasily: I just wanted to frighten you.

Vasily: I was planning to hide the girl, to make it seem like a warning from the demon, so that you and Arseny would stop. Without you, everyone else would agree to end this.

Vasily: I didn't think I would wake him.

Vasily: I brought the knife for a little courage. I never imagined—I thought ...

Vasily: Larissa, please forgive me.

Woman: Then the police took him away. I never saw him again, and they never found our girl.

Woman: I don't know if I truly hate him. He was a pitiable old man, driven insane by his hardships. But I know that I can't forgive him for what he's done.

Woman: I just hope to never see his face again.

Kiperina: ...

Kiperina has no response to the woman's story, only an ache of sympathy.

Reality cannot be changed, and any consolation she offers would be a futile gesture. She understands that more than anyone else.

Han Zhang: *sigh* I'm such a mushy little salamander. I just can't handle stuff like this.

The little salamander swishes its tail and hangs its head over the side of its container.

The cabin falls into silence.

Until at last, Kiperina sees the woman's eyes lift up and out the window.

Woman: Oh, would you look at that? The snow's stopped.

Kiperina: Hmm? It really has.

Woman: Do you see those two small hills over there?

Kiperina moves closer to the window.

Kiperina: You mean those two there side-by-side?

Woman: That's where he said he left our girl in the divot between them. He wanted to shelter her from the wind.

Woman: She was somewhere around there.

Kiperina finally understands.

Kiperina: That's why you come here so often?

Kiperina: You're still looking for her?

Woman: It's the only thing I have to go on.

Woman: Some days I imagine that I might see a kind old woman holding a little girl's hand, saying, "I found you here many years ago, you know ..."

Woman: Who knows. It's possible, isn't it?

The woman offers a heartbreaking smile, and Kiperina feels again at a loss to speak.

A child left alone in the snow—how could she have survived? It's impossible. It would take a miracle if someone finds her by accident.

Kiperina: Hold on.

The realization hits her like a bullet, ricocheting around in her chest.

Kiperina: Then your child was lost around here during a snowstorm. When did this happen?

Kiperina: Did she have her name stitched onto her blanket?

Kiperina: What was her name?

The idea seems impossible to consider, but—

As soon as the thought enters her head, it cannot be dismissed. The chaos leaves her mind blank, and Kiperina holds her breath.

After a long pause, she watches the woman open her mouth confusedly.

Woman: Daksha. Her name is Daksha.

Woman: She is my eldest daughter.

Kiperina: ...

Kiperina: Oh, I see.

Is it disappointment or relief she feels in the pit of her stomach? She responds blankly, pausing as if unsure of what to say next.

Fortunately, the sound of the door opening breaks the pause before it looms too heavily.

Girl: Mamma!

Boy: I knew you were here, Mamma! But you didn't tell us this time.

Boy: Uhm. Who's this lady?

Message from Afar

COL-311708

Woman: Anton, Yulia! How many times do I have to tell you? Why won't you ever listen to me?

Woman: It's such a long journey here. What if something had happened to you during that storm?

In response to the woman's scolding, the boy points toward the door.

Anton: We didn't come here on our own.

Yulia: Elisha came with us!

Elisha: WOOF!

Woman: What am I to do with all of you!

Caught between laughter and tears, the woman rubs her forehead in exasperation, while two sets of curious, wide eyes direct their attention to Kiperina.

Anton: Mamma, is she Daksha?

Yulia: Is this our sister? Are you Daksha?

The woman knocks gently on their little heads.

Woman: You're avoiding my questions. And why do you think everyone we meet must be Daksha?

Woman: Daksha still has a few years more before she would grow as tall as this sister.

Observing this interaction between the mother and her children, Kiperina smiles, but soon a question arises in her thoughts.

Kiperina: And these kids, they are ...

Woman: This is my son, Anton, and beside him is his sister, Yulia.

Woman: Don't let their innocent looks fool you; they're both little rascals. They inherited Arseny's spirit, no doubt.

Anton: Hello, miss.

Yulia: Hi!

Kiperina: I see. It's nice to meet you both. But ...

Kiperina thinks carefully about how to phrase her next words without causing offense, but the little salamander in her pocket pays no mind to matters of social etiquette.

Han Zhang: Hold on. I thought you said your husband croaked!?

Han Zhang: But you've got two little ones here after all that? I mean, uh, how did that happen?

Kiperina: Mr. Han Zhang! That's such a rude question.

She looks at the woman anxiously, seeing her eyes widen in surprise before she bursts into laughter.

Woman: Oh, my goodness! It's my fault. You misunderstood.

Woman: My husband was badly hurt in the attack. He still finds it hard to leave the house, but my Arseny is alive and well.

Woman: I don't remember much of that night, just that I was rushing through the dorm looking for them, until I spotted Arseny lying in the snow.

Woman: They say I was the one who stopped his bleeding, and I shouted so loudly, louder than they'd ever heard, for everyone to get him to the hospital.

Woman: Looking back, I must say, I'm quite impressed with myself.

Han Zhang: Oh, so that's the deal! Yeah, I got to admit I completely misunderstood.

Han Zhang shakes its head, as if relieved. After processing the details, Kiperina allows herself to smile again.

Kiperina: That's wonderful. So Arseny is alive! That's such very good news.

Kiperina: Still alive, still able to see and speak to each other. There's nothing better.

She shifts her gaze to the two little ones watching Han Zhang with intense curiosity.

Kiperina: Anton, Yulia, such good names.

Kiperina: It seems I was just worrying for nothing. I thought ...

She still believes that the woman before her is trapped in the memories of the blizzard long ago.

Perhaps she doesn't have the right to say it, but deep down, she understands—

Woman: Life must go on. We must all keep looking forward.

Woman: I've been searching for her ever since, and I still cry for her often.

Woman: But I have a good life with Arseny and our children. We have to let ourselves find happiness again.

She looks over to her two young children, her expression deep in both longing and joy.

Woman: Even after Anton was born, I found myself worrying that maybe Daksha would hold it against me.

Kiperina: No, it's not like that. You're such a good person, and I'm sure your daughter Daksha must also be a wonderful child.

Kiperina: None of this is your fault; Daksha would not want you to be unhappy.

Kiperina: At least, if it were me, I'd hope that those I care about, and those who care about me, would find happiness again.

In that moment, Kiperina feels something stir in her heart.

Woman: Yes. This may just be wishful thinking, but I think ...

Woman: Those who are bound by love share their hearts forever, and those who love us hope for our happiness as well.

Woman: I will always have a place for her in my heart. But there is room enough for others, for Arseny, for Anton, and for Yulia. A heart can never be too full; it expands to fit new love.

Woman: And I know she would love them just as I do.

Yulia: Yup, we all would!

Anton: Of course!

The two children bounce over to her, and the woman pulls them into her arms. Their expressions matching in warmth and tenderness.

Woman: I struggled with it for a long time, but in the end, my children helped me understand.

Woman: It's the love we receive that gives us the strength to overcome our suffering.

Woman: That's how we are able to move forward from tragedy, to find our future without losing the past.

She meets Kiperina's eyes, glistening teardrops illuminated by the sunlight pouring in from the window.

Woman: I don't know what happened to you, but ...

Woman: Perhaps you'd be willing to share it with us?

For a moment, Kiperina feels as though she too is wrapped in their embrace.

But the truth about the "Storm" cannot be disclosed to outsiders, and so the truth has to remain with her.

Kiperina: I am looking for a circus, the Utrennyaya Circus.

Kiperina: However, it seems I've come to the wrong place. They're not here.

Yulia: Utrennyaya!

Anton: We know Utrennyaya!

Kiperina: Hmm?

The two children scramble to pull out a crumpled poster from Anton's pocket.

Anton: Look!

Kiperina: This is ...!

The familiar lettering on the poster leaves Kiperina on the edge of tears.

Kiperina: It's true. But why? It really is Utrennyaya!

Anton: Because you're in the wrong place, lady. Look, it says, "The performance of a lifetime awaits you in Kandalaksha! See you there."

Anton: The show is in Kandalaksha, not here.

Yulia: We want to watch the show as well, but the postman said we won't make it in time.

Yulia: He said it's really, really far away.

Woman: Let me see. Oh, yes, I'm afraid it is, children.

The woman takes the poster into her hands and shakes her head regretfully at the children.

Woman: It says their performance starts at seven, but Kandalaksha is over 200 kilometers away. We'd never make it in time.

Woman: How about this? I'll ask the postman to keep an eye out for news about the circus, so we'll know when their next show is.

Woman: I'll take you next time, okay?

Yulia: Fine.

Anton: And that's a promise now, Mamma!

The two children nod obediently, but she can't help but feel the same disappointment she sees in their eyes.

Kiperina: Wait, maybe ...

She reaches into her pocket.

Kiperina: Maybe I can take you there.

Kiperina: To Utrennyaya.

The Days After

COL-311709

Circus Member: Welcome, welcome, distinguished guests!

Circus Member: I guarantee today's performance will exceed your wildest expectations!

Moving with the crowd, Kiperina walks into the tent.

Even now she cannot quite determine if the thumping in her chest is from fear or excitement.

However, all her doubt vanishes as the performance starts.

Circus Stage

Circus Member: Now, please welcome our amazing, death-defying virtuoso of the trapeze—Talia!

Amidst the roaring cheers, a lithe young woman steps onto the tightrope.

Yulia: Wow!

Anton: The way she walks is so incredible! It's just like ... like ...

Kiperina: Just like walking on air.

Kiperina gazes upward, focusing on the figure suspended in midair.

It's a girl she has never seen before. All the circus members, both onstage and off, are people she's never seen before.

This isn't her Utrennyaya. Her last glimmer of hope falls away into oblivion.

But strangely, somehow, her heart continues to beat steadily and strongly.

Kiperina: She's amazing! I think she might even be better than I was.

The performance is breathtaking, lighting up the faces of the crowd.

Even with everything so unfamiliar, this is the Utrennyaya she has longed for, the one she feared losing but ultimately had to part with.

Her home.

Kiperina: I had almost forgotten what it was like.

Kiperina: This is what it feels like to watch someone walk a tightrope.

It feels as though this other person has taken her place, flying into the sky, toward the great unknown, flying to the farthest reaches of the universe. Then she looks up.

Up to the canopy that once covered the sky and created a small world for her, cramped but cozy.

But now, it no longer covers her. It was torn away in the storm. This canopy is not the same.

It was different from the one she once knew.

Kiperina: So that's what it's like. I understand now.

It is only when gazing into the universe that one can truly comprehend their own insignificance.

And it is only by looking back at the past and then into the future, immersed in this invisible river of time, that one can truly know—

Kiperina: I see. This moment, right now. There will never be another moment like it.

The resolve that once stirred in her heart now finds firm ground, and she stands more certain than ever.

The past has given her the courage to move forward, and the future still holds hope worth reaching for—

There is no reason to stop moving forward.

Circus Member: Thank you, everyone, for gracing us with your patronage and your applause. What a wonderful audience! Today's show has come at last to its conclusion!

Woman: I know it might sound surprising, but this is actually my first time at the circus. It was even more exciting than I imagined.

Woman: Thank you for bringing us here.

The woman sitting beside her turns to face her, but her words trail off midway.

A moment later, she gives her a knowing look.

Woman: You're leaving, aren't you?

Kiperina: Yes.

Waves of applause are still crashing around her, but Kiperina has already risen from her seat.

She reaches into her pocket and pulls out her last teleport disk.

Kiperina: Ms. Larissa, Anton, Yulia ...

Kiperina: I think I should go.

Now, she moves onward into the future, into the unknown.

[English text unavailable]

COL-311710

Banquet Hall

The grand hall is filled to bursting with guests. Some dressed in formal attire, while others are still in uniforms or researchers' coats that seem just a little out of place.

Among the crowd, Pointer is one of them.

Foundation Staff Member: Ms. Pointer, I must say, we're quite fascinated by your team's research.

Foundation Staff Member: Will we have the chance to meet the other team members? Maybe Ms. Hissabeth or your young astronaut?

Pointer: Of course, I'd be more than happy to introduce them to you.

Pointer: However, first, I was asked by Mr. Ludwig to inquire whether your branch would be willing to work with our team in Plesetsk on the distribution and utilization of runium.

Pointer: Perhaps we can find the time to discuss those details first.

Despite her robotic nature, Pointer always seems more adept at social responsibilities. Not far off, Hissabeth is savoring the last bite of her dessert.

Hissabeth: Délicieux! Soufflé should be eaten immediately after it's baked. The Foundation's chefs certainly know what they're doing.

Snake I: I'm more interested in the lamb chops over there. Come on, bring us another plate!

Hissabeth: Not the best choice. I don't want to stuff myself on that. I'd rather try the steak tartare next.

Another pointless sibling dispute seems poised to launch before they're interrupted by the arrival of a friend.

Name Day: Ms. Hissabeth.

Hissabeth: Registration all done? Did everything go smoothly?

Voyager smiles and nods in reply.

Voyager: *nod*

Hissabeth: It does seem that we're just waiting on one last person.

Name Day: Has Ms. Kiperina still not arrived? That's unusual.

Hissabeth: Well, I get the feeling she finds these sorts of gatherings a bit dull, non?

Hissabeth: I have no objections if she wants to enjoy life and not be tied down in endless useless conversation, not like anyone's taking attendance today.

Her tone remains light, but the young man frowns nonetheless.

Name Day: Maybe we shouldn't have let her ...

Before he can finish speaking, he sees Voyager's eyes brighten.

Recalling his assigned task, the young man promptly follows.

Voyager: Alia!

Kiperina: Voyager, here you are! There are so many people; I was afraid I'd never find you.

Kiperina: And Mr. Name Day, hello. Sorry for being late.

Name Day: No need to apologize. I just can't remember you ever being late for anything before.

Name Day: Was there something keeping you?

Kiperina: When Larissa heard I was going to a banquet, she insisted on helping me with my outfit. I tried on a few things, but none of them felt quite right.

Kiperina: I finally settled on my regular outfit. That's why I'm a little late. But Larissa still helped with my braid. How does it look?

Voyager: It's beautiful, Alia.

Name Day: It sounds like you've made some fine friends recently.

Kiperina's warm grin dispels the last of Name Day's worries, and Voyager begins to hum a cheerful melody.

A bouquet of white flowers is presented to Kiperina, with a subtle fragrance that caresses the tip of her nose.

Kiperina: This is ... for me?

Voyager: *nod*

A peculiar unspoken understanding allows Kiperina to quickly grasp what her friend is trying to say.

Kiperina: Thank you, Voyager. So these are the flowers you found along your journey. They're so pretty.

Kiperina: I'm happy to hear you also had fun on your travels.

After tucking away the exotic flowers, Kiperina looks around the hall.

Name Day: Who are you looking for? Ms. Windsong, or perhaps Hissabeth?

Name Day: Just a while ago, I ran into Ms. Windsong. She told me she'd like to introduce you to Avgust, Nina, Pyotr, and some of her other students.

Yet, as they scan the room, there's no sign of Windsong.

Name Day: I do recall Madam Lucy asking around for her, so you'll probably have to wait a while.

Name Day: As for Ms. Hissabeth, she's right over there.

She follows his hand to a familiar figure perusing the snacks nearby.

Hissabeth: ...

She obviously notices her, yet after a quick glance, she heads toward the exit.

It's a clear signal to follow her. Kiperina matches her speed and exits the room.

They proceed down the corridor, moving ahead until they are alone, and the noise of the crowd is barely audible.

Hissabeth: Ah, the air here is so much fresher, though it is a little cool.

Hissabeth: It's still winter, but after the "Storm," it feels warmer than before. Might just be my senses playing tricks on me, though. I suppose I'll have to check the data when we get back.

Kiperina: Maybe I should have dressed more formally. I didn't think the banquet would be this big.

Hissabeth: No worries, kid. This banquet isn't just for us, anyway.

Hissabeth: In fact, after the last "Storm," Laplace was in utter disarray, but it was Madam Lucy who finally helped put things back in order.

Hissabeth: Things weren't much better here at the Foundation. With the "Storm" back for another round, everyone is in need of some good news.

Hissabeth: Then they'd finally be able to stop working and, if it's even possible, relax.

Hissabeth: Cause if we can finally do that, if we can smile again, then no matter how much damage the "Storm" does, we'll one day make a molehill out of this mountain.

Kiperina: Are you saying that we're the good news? And this party is for everyone else?

Hissabeth: We're just an excuse for everyone else to have fun. There's no gratitude in this world at all, n'est-ce pas?

Kiperina: That's wonderful. Who would've thought our hard work would pay off so well? Looks like it's good news for me as well.

Hissabeth: You ... You've changed a little since I last saw you, non?

Hissabeth looks at the girl inquisitively; it's a look of scientist pleased at their dissection.

Hissabeth: In fact, I've got another tidbit of news. It's still under wraps, but I imagine the Foundation will release it soon enough.

Hissabeth: Either way, it's something I have no doubt you'll be interested in.

She leans over to Kiperina, her voice dropping to a whisper.

Hissabeth: They found someone who can brave the "Storm."

Kiperina's mind goes blank for a moment, as she takes a moment to consider the significance of the statement.

Kiperina: Are you saying that ...?

Hissabeth: Apparently, she's a student at the SPDM. She's to be named the Timekeeper and will take on the responsibility of solving the mystery of the "Storm."

Hissabeth: Now, the Foundation may refuse to lend us this individual, but I'm certain we can obtain further data from this Timekeeper.

Hissabeth: So we now have a secret weapon. We've made another stride in unraveling this damned "Storm" puzzle.

Hissabeth's slit pupils twitch with excitement, and Kiperina feels a wave of emotion rise within her.

Kiperina: This is really really good news.

She had already come to terms with the fact that her efforts, past and future, might not bear immediate fruit.

But then maybe she had been too pessimistic. It appears a spark of hope has now been ignited.

Hissabeth: Hmm? What's that you've got there?

The flowery bouquet she received from Voyager earlier pokes out into view.

Kiperina: Voyager gave me these flowers that she picked on her journey here. I feel like I've seen them before, but I don't really know what they're called.

Kiperina: What's wrong?

Hissabeth looks perplexed.

Hissabeth: These are lilacs.

Hissabeth: You're sure she picked them? Because wild lilacs only bloom in the spring. Quel bizarre.

She laughs suddenly.

Hissabeth: I must be losing my mind, too busy to even remember the time of year.

Kiperina laughs along.

Kiperina: Yes, Ms. Hissabeth. Look.

Kiperina: Spring is here already.